put behind it many of the post-decolonization debates of this region. It navigated the Cold War very adeptly to usher in an era of high economic growth that served as a model to others. Weathering the impact of the Asian financial crisis in 1997, it then went on to actually expand its footprint through the East Asia Summit process. All its members benefited from the more open global economic architecture and largely came through the 2008 crisis as well.

Today, however, they confront multiple stress tests and it is important that India is for them a part of the solution. The challenges they face include new power equilibriums, greater political unpredictability, issues of rules and norms, uncertain geo-economic directions, the question of internal cohesion and perhaps even of the centrality of ASEAN to Asia's future.

This is, therefore, exactly the right moment for India to expand its engagement with the group, adding dimensions like security, strengthening connectivity and doing more business. But beyond that, Indian strategic interests warrant that ASEAN's centrality is preserved, if not strengthened. All its bilateral and regional energies must be utilized to that end. Furthermore, as new concepts like Indo-Pacific gain traction, it is important that ASEAN is made to feel comfortable with them. They must be persuaded that a larger strategic domain would both conceptually and literally put them more at its centre. Similarly, mechanisms like Quad or Trilaterals should be seen visibly as supportive of ASEAN objectives. Sustained signalling to that effect is very much the need of the day.

The story of the ASEAN-India partnership started at the 1992 Singapore Summit, with India becoming a full Dialogue Partner in 1996, a Summit Partner in 2002 and a Strategic Partner in 2012. The special Commemorative Summit to mark its Silver Jubilee brought the leaders of all ten ASEAN nations for the 2018 Republic Day celebrations in New Delhi. A message by itself, it also underlined how much this relationship had filled out during this period. Historically and culturally, the links between India and South-East Asia have been deep and profound. Expressions of shared heritage and culture are found across the region. Indeed, some of the best surviving examples of Indian civilization over the ages are there.